

Coaching Conversation Starter Questions

FREE RESOURCE · LEADERSHIP & FACILITATION

Coaching Conversation Starter Questions

50 powerful coaching questions organised by conversation stage — opening, exploring, challenging, and committing to action — with guidance on when to use each one.

50 Questions

4 Conversation Stages

When to Use Each

Active Listening Guide

50

questions

4

stages

8

listening reminders

1

conversation flow

HOW TO USE

These questions follow the natural arc of a coaching conversation — from opening and exploring, through to challenging and committing to action. You do not need to use every question in every session, and you rarely need to move through the stages in a straight line. Choose the question that fits where the client actually is, not where the framework says they should be.

A NOTE ON POWERFUL QUESTIONS

A powerful coaching question is open, not leading — it invites the client to think, not to guess what answer you want. It is usually short. And it almost always starts with "what" or "how" rather than "why", which can trigger justification instead of reflection.

CONVERSATION STAGE

8 questions

Opening

Build rapport quickly, understand what the client actually wants from this conversation, and agree what would make it worthwhile.

01 What would make this conversation genuinely useful for you today?

Use when: Opening any session, especially the first with a new client.

02 What's on your mind right now that you'd like to explore?

Use when: The client hasn't yet named a clear topic.

03 If we only had time to focus on one thing today, what would it be?

Use when: Time is limited and focus is needed early.

04 What's changed since we last spoke that's worth bringing into today's conversation?

Use when: This is an ongoing coaching relationship, not a first session.

05 On a scale of 1 to 10, how are you feeling about where things stand — and what makes it that number and not one lower?

Use when: You want a quick, honest read on where the client is starting from.

06 What would need to happen in this conversation for you to leave feeling it was time well spent?

Use when: You want the client to define success for the session themselves.

07 What's the real topic underneath the topic you just mentioned?

Use when: The stated topic feels like it may be masking something bigger.

08 Before we dive in, is there anything getting in the way of you being fully present right now?

Use when: The client seems distracted, rushed, or elsewhere mentally.

CONVERSATION STAGE

16 questions

Exploring

Deepen understanding of the situation — the facts, the feelings, the context, and the patterns the client may not yet see clearly themselves.

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- 09 What does this situation actually look like, in specific detail?**
Use when: The client is speaking in generalities rather than specifics.
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- 10 What have you already tried, and what happened when you did?**
Use when: You want to avoid suggesting something the client has already attempted.
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- 11 Who else is involved in this, and how do they see it?**
Use when: The situation involves other people whose perspective hasn't been considered.
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- 12 What's the story you're telling yourself about why this is happening?**
Use when: The client's account sounds like interpretation rather than fact.
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- 13 What would someone with no stake in this situation notice that you might be missing?**
Use when: The client seems too close to the situation to see it objectively.
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- 14 What's the cost of this situation continuing exactly as it is?**
Use when: The client seems to be tolerating something without examining its price.
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- 15 What part of this is actually within your control?**
Use when: The client is focused on things they cannot influence.
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- 16 What are you not saying that might be important?**
Use when: You sense there's more beneath the surface of the conversation.
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- 17 How long has this been building, and what's changed recently?**
Use when: You want to understand whether this is new or long-standing.
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- 18 What assumptions are you making that you haven't tested?**
Use when: The client presents a belief as fact without checking it.
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- 19 If you described this to someone you deeply respect, what would you want them to understand?**
Use when: You want to surface what the client sees as the core of the issue.
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- 20 What emotions come up when you think about this, and where do you feel them?**
Use when: The conversation feels purely intellectual and may benefit from more depth.
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- 21 What's worked in a similar situation before, even a different one?**
Use when: You want to draw on the client's own existing resourcefulness.
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- 22 What would you need to know that you don't know yet?**
Use when: The client feels stuck and may be missing key information.
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- 23 Whose voice is loudest in your head about this — and is it actually right?**
Use when: The client's language suggests internalised pressure from someone else.
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- 24 What's the version of this story where you're not the victim of circumstances?**
Use when: The client's account leaves them with no agency or responsibility.
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CONVERSATION STAGE

14 questions

Challenging

Test assumptions, invite the client past their comfort zone, and surface what they may be avoiding without judgement.

25 What would you do here if you knew you couldn't fail?

Use when: Fear of failure appears to be limiting the client's options.

26 What's the real reason you haven't already done something about this?

Use when: The client has clearly identified an action but hasn't taken it.

27 Whose expectations are you actually trying to meet — yours or someone else's?

Use when: You suspect the client's goal may not fully be their own.

28 What are you protecting by staying where you are?

Use when: The client claims to want change but is not moving toward it.

29 If your best friend were in this exact situation, what would you tell them to do?

Use when: The client is harder on themselves than they would be on others.

30 What's the boldest version of the next step you could take?

Use when: The proposed action seems smaller than the client's actual ambition.

31 What would it cost you to be wrong about this?

Use when: The client seems certain about something worth questioning.

32 What are you avoiding by focusing on this instead of the harder issue underneath it?

Use when: The stated topic feels like a safer substitute for something more significant.

33 If this were easy, what would you already have done?

Use when: The client is framing a solvable problem as more difficult than it is.

34 What's the belief you're holding onto that might not actually be true?

Use when: A limiting belief appears to be driving the client's account of events.

35 What would change if you stopped waiting for permission?

Use when: The client is deferring a decision that is theirs to make.

36 Who do you need to become to make this decision differently?

Use when: The client's identity, not just their circumstances, seems to be the barrier.

37 What's the story that's more comfortable, and what's the story that's more true?

Use when: The client's narrative sounds rehearsed rather than examined.

38 If you knew this conversation was your last chance to be honest about this, what would you say?

Use when: The client has been circling a topic without naming it directly.

CONVERSATION STAGE

12 questions

Committing to Action

Convert insight into a concrete, owned next step — with enough specificity and accountability that it actually happens.

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- 39 What's the very first thing you'll do, and by when?**
Use when: The conversation has produced insight but no committed action yet.
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- 40 What does success look like in the next two weeks?**
Use when: The goal feels distant and needs a nearer-term marker.
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- 41 What could get in the way, and how will you handle it if it does?**
Use when: The client has a track record of good intentions that don't follow through.
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- 42 Who needs to know about this decision, and when will you tell them?**
Use when: The action depends on or affects other people.
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- 43 What support do you need, and from whom?**
Use when: The client is planning to tackle something significant alone.
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- 44 How will you know if this is working?**
Use when: The plan lacks a way to measure progress.
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- 45 What's the smallest version of this step you could take today?**
Use when: The full action feels too large to start immediately.
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- 46 What would make you abandon this plan — and is that a good enough reason?**
Use when: You want to pressure-test the client's real commitment.
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- 47 How will you hold yourself accountable if no one else is checking in?**
Use when: There is no external accountability structure in place.
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- 48 What are you willing to commit to out loud, right now?**
Use when: You want to convert a private intention into a spoken commitment.
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- 49 If you don't do this, what will still be true in six months?**
Use when: The client may be underestimating the cost of inaction.
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- 50 What's one thing you want me to follow up on with you next time we speak?**
Use when: You are closing the session and setting up the next one.
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Active Listening Reminders

The questions in this guide only work if the listening around them is strong. These eight reminders are worth returning to before any significant coaching conversation.

01 Let silence do its work.

A pause of three to five seconds feels longer to you than it does to the client. Their best insight often comes right after you feel the urge to fill the silence — resist it.

02 Listen for repetition and emphasis.

Words or phrases a client returns to more than once, or stresses more heavily, usually point to what matters most — even when the client hasn't consciously noticed it.

03 Notice what isn't said.

A topic the client consistently talks around, rather than through, is often more significant than the ones they address directly.

04 Reflect back their own words.

Paraphrasing into your own language can subtly shift the client's meaning. Reflecting their exact words back signals that you were truly listening, not translating.

05 Watch for shifts in energy.

A change in tone, pace, posture, or facial expression as a question lands often tells you more than the verbal answer that follows it.

06 Don't plan your next question while they're still speaking.

You cannot fully listen while composing what you'll say next. Trust that the right next question will come once you've actually heard the answer.

07 Ask one question at a time.

Stacking two or three questions together lets the client answer the easiest one and quietly avoid the rest. Ask, then stop.

08 Stay curious, not directive.

If you notice yourself hoping for a particular answer, you have stopped coaching and started steering. Return to genuine curiosity about what is true for the client.

THE REAL SKILL

The best coaching questions are rarely the cleverest ones — they are the ones that come from genuinely listening to what the client just said, rather than from a list prepared in advance. Use this guide to build your range, then let the conversation itself decide which question comes next.